THE HINDU
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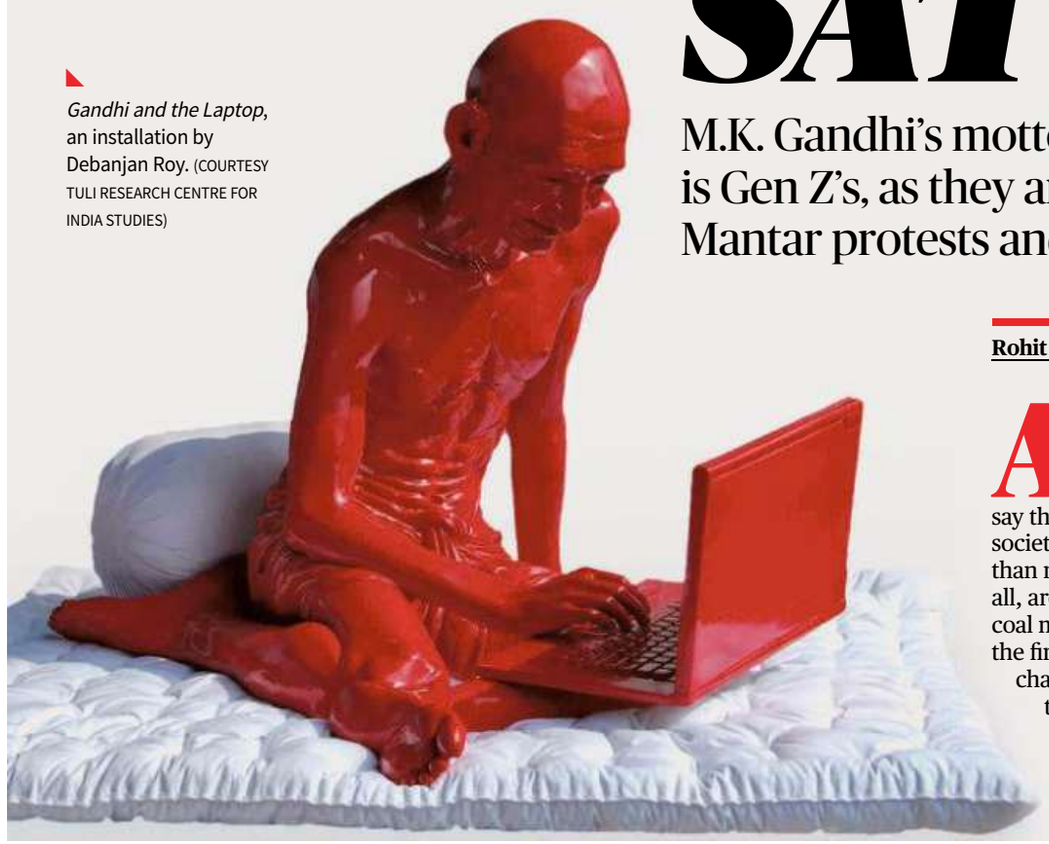
LITERARY REVIEW

Ramachandra Guha's new book on the Mahatma

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THE YOUNG AND THE SATYAGRAHA



Gandhi and the Laptop, an installation by Debanjan Roy. (COURTESY TULI RESEARCH CENTRE FOR INDIA STUDIES)

M.K. Gandhi's motto was truth and non-violence, and so too is Gen Z's, as they amply demonstrated during the Jantar Mantar protests and in subsequent movements

Rohit Kumar

As an educator who has taught high school students for the past three decades, I often say that teachers observe shifts in societal morality more closely than most. Young people, after all, are often the 'canary in the coal mine' of society, and usually the first to reflect the deeper changes taking place around them.

I caught a disturbing glimpse of one such shift three years ago, when I showed an auditorium full of Class IX students Richard Attenborough's 1980 film, *Gandhi*. The movie begins with Mahatma Gandhi's assassination, and as Godse pumps three bullets into the frail old man, the students in the darkened hall begin clapping, cheering, and whistling, leaving me stunned.

That evening, I sent a mail to all the students asking them why they thought it was okay to applaud a murder. A great number of them wrote back and apologised, saying they were ashamed at what had happened and had just gotten caught up in the moment. A few, however, proudly admitted to leading the cheering and said, "Gandhi was a bad man and deserved to be shot." It comforted me, though, that they were in the minority.

The principal of the school, upset as she was about the behaviour of the students, insisted I show the film to Class VIII as well. Once again, a few students hooted and clapped at the assassination scene. I paused the movie and asked how they would feel if something similar happened to an elderly person they loved.

The proverbial 'pin-drop silence' followed. They got the point.

After the movie ended, I asked them if it is still possible to launch and win a Gandhian revolution in this day and age. The students weren't sure, and so I showed them video footage I had taken of the year-long farmers' peaceful and courageous protest at the border of Delhi in 2020-2021, which resulted in the Modi government repealing the three contentious, pro-corporate farm laws it had unilaterally passed.

I had interviewed many of the farmers, including one who said on camera, "They can beat us, maim us or shoot us. We will take the blows but not fight back. We will sit here till these laws are repealed."

At this point, a student jumped up and excitedly shouted, "Gandhi *zinda hai*!" (Gandhi is alive).

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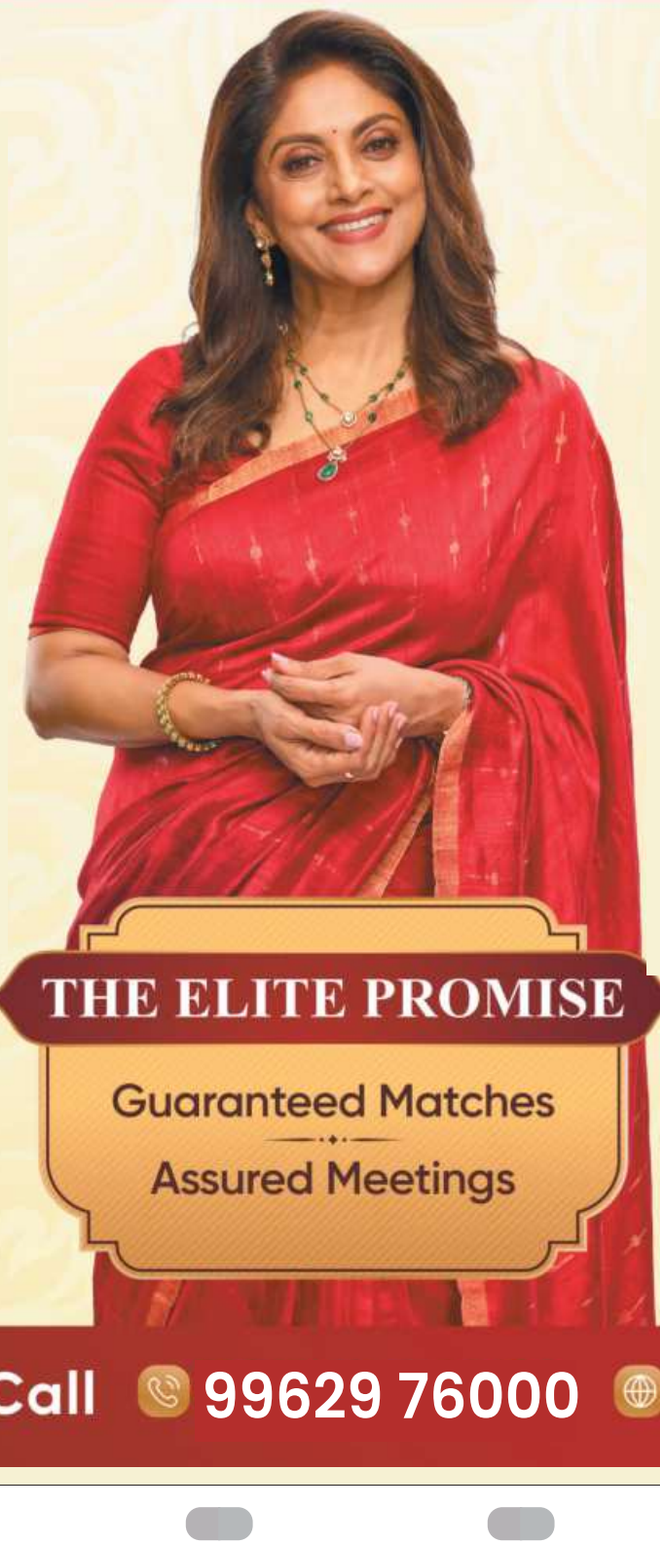
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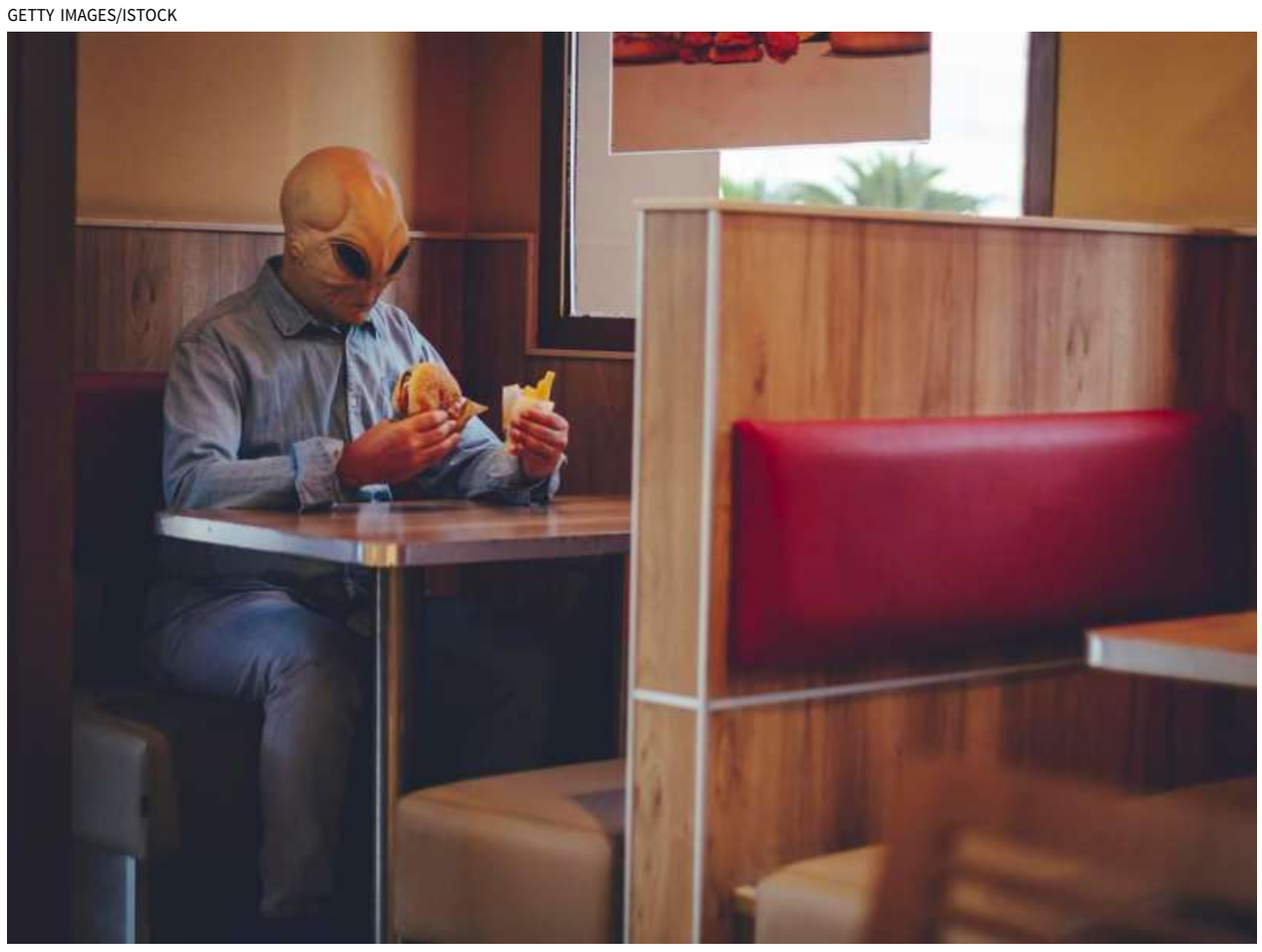
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2026 BOOKER PRIZE-SHORTLISTED

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ALIENS ARE HERE

Fantasy-fiction doyen M. John Harrison taps into the chaos of the present, not to arrive at some final truth but to turn our gaze inwards

Vasudevan Mukunth
mukunth.v@thehindu.co.in

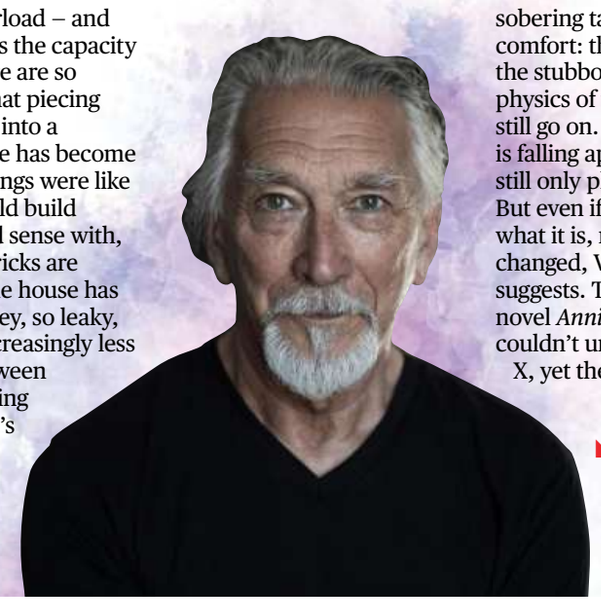
Can you explain what's happening? This has become an increasingly valuable question to answer.

To understand what's happening is to piece the increasingly chaotic present together and, in the cracked picture that forms, identify the future we're constantly moving into. It's an exercise in identifying which truths matter most at a time when truth is often the thing being contested, from social media platforms to debates in Parliament. And even when something becomes clear to you, and you cling desperately to it lest it fade away, the world itself moves on and you find yourself marooned on an island surrounded by more claims and counterclaims.

Forget the information overload. We're in the confusion overload – and confusion lacks the capacity to clarify. There are so many truths that piecing them together into a coherent whole has become fraught. Meanings were like bricks you could build houses of good sense with, but now the bricks are eroding and the house has become so holey, so leaky, that there's increasingly less difference between what it's standing for and what it's standing against. And the best you can do when your walls crumble is to go with the flow, and stick your hand out from time to time if you're feeling whimsical, taking your chances with whatever curiosity you can pluck from the torrent.

That's actually Phillip Tennent in *The End of Everything*, the British fantasy-fiction doyen M. John Harrison's latest novel that's made its way into the 2026 Booker Prize shortlist. Phillip's world has slipped from barely making sense to almost literally falling apart following a bizarre event.

Harrison is treading the same path here that he's been on since his 'Viriconium' series (1971-1984), but by now – he's 81 and will become the oldest Booker laureate if he wins – he's also joined by László Krasznahorkai and Jeff VanderMeer, among many others. Which shouldn't be surprising: it's a sincerely pleasant irony that the world's increasingly overt descent into





The End of Everything
M. John Harrison
Serpent's Tail
₹599

incomprehension and solipsism has also presented to each generation's best writers the chance to become the prophets we're looking for.

Disasters get exploited

In *The Melancholy of Resistance* (1989), Krasznahorkai ends his sobering tale with one comfort: that when we die, the stubbornly secular physics of the universe will still go on. Yes, the universe is falling apart, too, but it's still only physics at work. But even if physics is still what it is, metaphysics has changed, VanderMeer suggests. The people in his novel *Annihilation* (2014) couldn't understand Area X, yet there it was, with its own absurd yet systematic way of working. And the people still did well to not ignore that.

But the point of *The End of Everything* is that there's no one final truth. It's just evermore relativism – moral, physical, whatever. The aliens aren't really invading. They're just there, so are the people, and they seem to have no use for each other. Harrison shuts the door on the aliens' history by making it pointless even as he throws the door open to how much humans still don't know, and may never.

What then? Repeatedly, thus, *The End* deflects its gaze inwards, through the touching, if also frustrating, inner lives of Phillip, his aunt Marnie, the dreadfully pragmatic Hampson, and the still-not-pitiable Gauf brothers. In fact, the only thing Harrison and Krasznahorkai agree on is that disasters get exploited by the people who were already doing well.

Committing to the banal

Harrison's chapters are short and the narrative is discontinuous. You're carried along because you're part of the torrent. It's as much as one can manage for a world history that's settled into uninterruptible decline plus the attendant salvaging. Four chapters retell the same accident with small differences. *The End* works because of its steadfast commitment to the banal. Even its one attempt to break free and paint a beautiful image is shattered by Marnie being Marnie. When the aliens appear over London, they sound like harmonium music and smell like fireworks and ice cream.

In VanderMeer's *Annihilation*, a scientist is undone by what she knows and half-wants to be. In Krasznahorkai's *The Melancholy*, Valuska is an innocent fellow who loves the stars and the town destroys him. But in *The End*, Harrison insists that trying to understand is neither noble nor tragic. You just do what you can. And maybe stick your hand out once in a while.

M. John Harrison will become the oldest Booker laureate if he wins this year. (THEBOOKERPRIZES.COM)

IN CONVERSATION

'Tech bros are still pushing the same garbage'

Author Luke Kennard on writing against the technocratic times in his novel *Black Bag*

Simar Bhasin

Luke Kennard's Booker-shortlisted novel, *Black Bag* (published by John Murray), is a social experiment in and of itself. Inspired by the 1967 experiment conducted by Charles Goetzinger, the story here is told through the eyes of the narrator-protagonist, a struggling actor, who is chosen to play 'black bag' for a university professor conducting his own experiment. A dark humour-infused satirical take on the campus novel, *Black Bag* defies easy literary categorisation. Here, the author discusses the thought process behind the novel and his future literary experiments. Edited excerpts:

Question: *What was it about the black bag experiment or the mere-exposure effect that inspired your novel?*
Answer: I was reading about attraction theory (an area of social psychology) for a completely different project, and the black bag experiment was referenced in a footnote. I loved it immediately, but the thing that struck me as interesting was what it would be like for the actor, rather than the participants, and the ideas the experiment was testing. So, I just started from there.

Q: *As with your previous works,* Black Bag *is brimming with social commentary, particularly the normalisation of late-capitalist technocratic ways of being.*
A: I think we *have* to meet the times we're writing in, we have to be willing to attend to those things. I was worried, when I was writing it (from around 2021) that it was going to take me years and that all the things I was angry about would have moved on or changed and that it would be obsolete. But,



thankfully, the tech bros are still pushing the same garbage. So, thanks to their utter spiritual and intellectual paucity, my novel stayed relevant.

Q: *The protagonist, who plays 'black bag', is shown to be constantly ruminating on the sad state of affairs in the creative arts. Do you share his views?*
A: Yes and no. I wanted him to be a kind of lightning rod to channel all of the creative frustrations of anyone who's trying to make any kind of art in the current climate, mine included. In the U.K., particularly, I feel like it's completely looked down on, shamed even, unless you're making a lot of money. But it was like that when I was a child, too. You only get to do this out of a sense of defiance, really.

Q: *What was your thinking behind the relationship between 'black bag' and the academic Justine Pearce in the novel?*
A: The narrator's relationship with Justine was initially a parody of the campus novel trope where a depressed middle-aged academic has an affair with a beautiful young student... I wanted to write the opposite of that. But then, I became more interested in their dynamic and what it gives him; that, paradoxically, he feels somehow seen or loved or accepted by Justine. I think she's actually a very loving person.

Q: *What are the differences in your approach as a writer when you are composing poems as opposed to writing prose?*
A: There's a playfulness to writing poetry, a kind of musical improvisation, but using an instrument I built myself out of scraps of other instruments. I find fiction harder, because it also has to be systematic, has to deliver on a story, has to justify the eight or so hours the reader has spent with it. When I'm writing poetry, I'm enjoying myself and I'm trying to express and articulate complex things which I think are worth exploring, to the extent that I've dedicated half my life to it. But nobody else particularly wants it or reads it. (*Laughs.*)

Q: *What would you like to write about next?*
A: I became obsessed with Robert W. Chambers' 19th century gothic masterpiece *The King in Yellow* a couple of years ago; particularly, the idea of a cursed play script that ruins the lives of anyone who reads it. I'm working on a novel that changes the script to a cursed Ph.D manuscript, partly because it's a good way of getting a network of characters together (the student, supervisors, examiners). I'm also gradually editing my *Selected Poems*, which has involved going over about 25 years of work. It's simultaneously fun and mortifying.

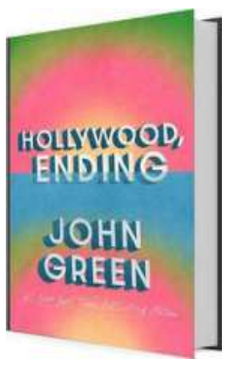
The interviewer is a Delhi-based literary critic and research scholar.



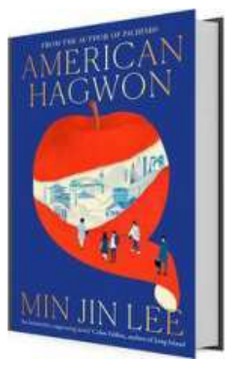
Luke Kennard has based his novel on an experiment conducted at Oregon State University in the U.S. in 1967. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

BROWSER

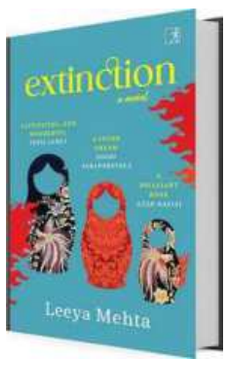
Hollywood, Ending
John Green
Penguin
₹899
In his first novel for adults, Green weaves a behind-the-scenes romance that examines the cost of fame and celebrity. It took him nine years to write this story of 'trauma, survival and finding love amid it all,' says the bestselling author of *The Fault In Our Stars*.



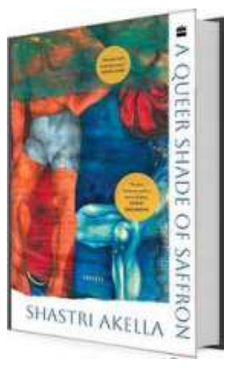
American Hagwon
Min Jin Lee
Fourth Estate
₹1,199
Among the most anticipated books of the year, this is the *Pachinko* author's first novel in nearly a decade, and the third book in her Korean diaspora series. The story follows the Koh family as they move from Seoul to California after the 1997 Asian financial crisis.



Extinction
Leeya Mehta
Simon & Schuster India
₹499
The author speaks of excavating silence through fiction and giving form to language that articulates painful experiences via this story of a multi-generational Parsi family. The cover features Russian doll-like figures draped in Gara embroidery, curated by designer Ashdeen Lilaowala.



A Queer Shade of Saffron
Shastri Akella
HarperCollins India
₹599
The stories in this collection span communities and landscapes, from pre-Partition Punjab to the Kashmir border to a small town in Gujarat, and explore varied hues of desire, intimacy and friendship. This is Akella's second work of fiction.



EXCERPT

BRINGING AMBEDKAR AND GANDHI TOGETHER

Their legacies need not be seen as competing, argues the historian in his new book

Ramachandra Guha

When meeting Gandhi in jail in 1932, Ambedkar told him: 'Let there be no repetition of the old method when the reformer claimed to know more of the requirements of his victims than the victims themselves.' Reading this warning now, almost a century later, one can see it as prescient. There had to come a time when Dalits would be represented by one of their own, rather than spoken for by a reformer from the upper-castes, however well-meaning he might be.

Gandhi's courage and resolve

Ambedkar's posthumous emergence as the great icon and exemplar of Dalits is thus entirely understandable. But whether the attacks on Gandhi by Ambedkarites are entirely merited is another matter. For Gandhi's own campaign against untouchability was conducted with great courage and resolve. Had he not been around, the issue may never have acquired the salience and importance that it did. None of his important colleagues in the Congress Party – not Jawaharlal Nehru, not Vallabhbhai Patel, not Subhas Chandra Bose – understood how gravely the cause of Indian independence was undermined by the pervasive inequalities of caste. Nor did left-wing anti-imperialists such as Bhagat Singh and company. Indeed, Indian Marxists completely ignored the caste question. This was because they looked at justice exclusively in economic terms, through the prism of their master category of 'class'. Derived from Marx's own focus on European history, this analytical framework had little (and often no) room for the social, cultural, and psychological aspects of caste discrimination in India.



GETTY IMAGES

Among the major Indian nationalists of the day, only Gandhi recognised the hypocrisy inherent in demanding freedom from the British while allowing so many Indians to live and suffer in conditions of unfreedom. Moreover, he saw it not just as a political problem, but a moral one. Untouchables had to be given equal rights so as to make a more persuasive case for India's political independence. At the same time, upper-castes Hindus had to atone for the 'sin' that untouchability represented.

While his fellow Congressmen were, by and large, indifferent to Gandhi's anti-untouchability campaign, a broad swathe of the general public was implacably opposed to it. Indeed, the unreasoning and extreme hostility to Gandhi from orthodox Hindus helps explain why he adopted an incremental approach in challenging caste prejudice. Between 1915 and 1920, when he was first establishing himself in Indian politics, he attacked untouchability without calling into question the caste system itself. As he grew more certain of his hold over the Indian people, and especially the Hindus among them, he began to encourage inter-mingling, inter-dining, and, eventually, inter-marriage itself.

Notably, as Gandhi's challenge to social orthodoxy became more direct, the opposition to him intensified. There was an unrelenting barrage of hate mails received by Gandhi for daring to question what his right-wing critics claimed was the divinely ordained hierarchy of caste. Adding to the verbal abuse were threats of violence, with at least one assassination attempt provoked by his anti-untouchability campaign.

Ambedkar saw Gandhi as a timid and hesitant reformer. Orthodox Hindus, on the other hand, saw Gandhi as a dangerous revolutionary attacking the very basis of scripture and tradition. This disjuncture in viewpoints brings to mind some comments of the great black abolitionist Frederick Douglass on his great white contemporary Abraham Lincoln. In a speech of 1876, Douglass remarked that 'viewed from the genuine abolition ground, Mr. Lincoln seemed tardy, cold, dull, and indifferent; but measuring him by the sentiment of his country, a sentiment he was bound as a statesman to consult, he was swift, zealous, radical, and determined.'

The two greatest opponents of untouchability in the first half of the twentieth century were Gandhi and Ambedkar. Their differing social locations and political affiliations produced sharp disagreements between the two men. In recent decades, as Dalits have grown more self-aware and better organised, they have turned more, much more, to Ambedkar than to Gandhi, to the activist intellectual who was himself a Dalit rather than to the guilt-ridden upper-caste reformer. This elevation of Ambedkar over Gandhi was inevitable, and appropriate. However, the politics of the present have also led to a wholesale repudiation of Gandhi on the part of those who seek to fight against the injustices of caste.

A posthumous reconciliation

When, back in the 1990s, this demonisation of Gandhi by Dalit activists was gathering pace, the social theorist D. R. Nagaraj wrote

an essay with the telling title 'Self-Purification versus Self-Respect', capturing the different paths taken by the two reformers. The self-purification of Gandhi sought to make upper castes abandon their arrogance and contempt for those whom the mere accident of birth had consigned to the bottom of the social hierarchy. The self-respect of Ambedkar was aimed at his fellow Dalits, urging them, as he famously put it, to 'educate, agitate, and organise' to claim rights of full and equal citizenship in the Indian Republic.

With the star of Ambedkar in the ascendance, Nagaraj reminded his readers that it was Gandhi who first made the eradication of untouchability 'one of the central questions of Indian politics.' Now, 'from the point of view of the present', he argued, there was 'a compelling necessity to achieve a synthesis' of the legacies of Ambedkar and Gandhi. To build a more caring and just society, one needed both to awaken afresh the upper-caste conscience and to consolidate the efforts for Dalit self-respect. Hence, insisted Nagaraj, 'Gandhiji and Ambedkar can and should be made complementary to each other.'

Nagaraj understood that his call for a posthumous reconciliation between two figures whom both history and politics had made implacable adversaries might not meet with approval. As he presciently wrote, 'surely such efforts will be met with stiff opposition from hardened ideologues and researchers, and they are bound to unearth fresh evidence to fuel the fire between the two'.

D. R. Nagaraj died a few years after writing these words. His call to bring these apparently opposed legacies in productive conversation has been continued by his friend, the Dalit novelist and activist Devanuru Mahadeva. Speaking to the journalist Amrita Dutta on the eve of Gandhi's 150th birth anniversary, Mahadeva urged democrats not to view Ambedkar and Gandhi as rivals and adversaries. In the journey towards true equality, he said, they should rather be seen as colleagues and co-workers. Thus, as Mahadeva remarked, 'Ambedkar had to awaken the sleeping Dalits and then make the journey. Gandhi had to make the immense effort of uplifting, correcting, changing those who were drowned in Hindu caste religion, in caste wells, to take a step forward. When you see all this, maybe Gandhi would not have traversed far without the presence of Ambedkar. Similarly, I feel that without the liberal tolerant atmosphere created by Gandhi in the wells of Hindu caste religion, then this cruel Savarna [upper caste] society may not have tolerated Ambedkar as much as it did then.'

Mahadeva continued: 'If it is our understanding that it is the Savarnas who need to change if India has to liberate itself from caste, then Gandhi is necessary. In the fight for Dalit civil rights, Ambedkar is absolutely necessary. Hence, I say that both should be brought together.' This is a sentiment which I whole-heartedly endorse.

Excerpted from Arguments with Gandhi (HarperCollins India).

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Trade routes that shaped India's history

Akshay Chavan's book shows how deeply the country has been connected to the wider world for centuries



An 8th-century Durga temple in Aihole, Karnataka. (GETTY IMAGES)

It is uncanny to read Akshay Chavan's *The Wealth Networks: How Roads, Rivers and Seas Shaped India* at a time when physical and trade wars are creating choke points in the movement of goods and services around the world.

While rooted in India, and in how geography and trade shaped its history, empires, kingdoms, and civilisations, the book is also outward-looking, tracing how these connected India to the wider world and contributed to the successive reconfigurations of globalisation across history.

From the past to the present

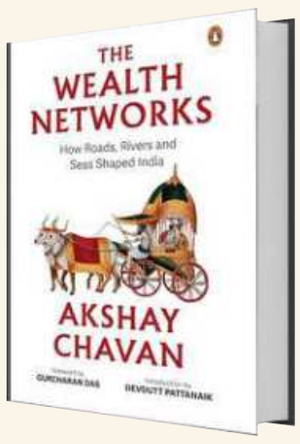
The Wealth Networks goes beyond history as a telling of the rise and fall of empires through the deeds and battles of its rulers to explain why kingdoms came up in specific sites, which goods enabled their enrichment, how they acquired economic leverage, and how certain religions spread. Kings and their battles, in fact, are relegated to a corner, reacting to the main drama of trade, deep-sea ports, monsoon winds, goods, pilgrimage routes, black-soil cotton, Western Ghats pepper, and the diamonds of Golconda.

Chavan demonstrates all this through an exhaustive perambulation across India's geography, at different points in its history. The book can be easily connected to what is unfolding at this moment in West Asia – the fight for control of the Strait of Hormuz and the Bab Al-Mandeb in the Red Sea. In a section devoted to the rice trade from the ports of Mangaluru to the Arabian Peninsula in the 12th and 13th centuries, the book not only details how food cultures in Arabia and North Africa changed with the export of rice from South Kanara, but also how a disruption in the rice trade from Mangaluru could lead to famine in Hormuz. It says, "Hormuz, at the mouth of the Persian Gulf, was a key trading hub. Its economy relied heavily on customs duties from Indian imports. Another vital city was Muscat in Oman, which distributed Kanara rice across Arabia. The profits were massive. Kanara rice sold at an 80% mark up in Muscat, making it a goldmine for Indian and Omani merchants alike."

Thus, when we read about the large number of Indian seamen on merchant vessels, and the Indian government speaking out time and again about their safety amid the U.S.-Iran war, India's dominance of this sea network becomes part of a much longer historical continuum.

A different map of history

There are two main things that the book does especially well. The first is to remove the centrality of North India from the telling of India's history and fill that space with the Cholas, Pandyas, Pallavas, Rashtrakutas, Tuluvas, Hoysalas, and others. These are names that school textbooks on Indian history barely manage to mention when they usually leap from Ashoka the Great to Akbar the Great.



The Wealth Networks: How Roads, Rivers and Seas Shaped India
Akshay Chavan
Penguin Random House
₹999

The second is to show how the patronage of trading classes to priests, mendicants, sculptors, and other artists mattered in creating a sacred geography of major pilgrimage routes and towns, such as Aihole in Karnataka, around the more temporal routes of trade.

Chavan also explains the etymology of names of certain places in India. For example, Ghodbunder in Thane is said to have been named for the spot where the Portuguese took delivery of Arab horses – *ghoda*, from the Prakrit word *ghodaya*, meaning horse, and *bunder*, the Persian word for port, together gave the place its name.

The book is written in an accessible manner and offers an uncommon angle from which to view Indian history: its connectivity with the world from ancient times and its centrality to world trade over the centuries.

Some contemporary trade negotiators may profit from reading this book, if nothing else but to remind themselves that it is geography that shapes history far more than the whims of a single ruler; that what connects the world is always more than what keeps it apart.



Gen G Youngsters at the Cockroach Janta Party-led protests in Delhi this July. (GETTY IMAGES)

THE YOUNG AND THE *SATYAGRAHA*

CONTINUED ON
» PAGES 4-5

Echoes of another era

Those of us who felt that we would never again see a Gandhian movement like the farmers' protest, at least in our lifetime, were joyfully surprised when Gen Z dug in at Jantar Mantar a few months ago and refused to budge till Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned.

Abhijeet Dipke and the Cockroach Janta Party he founded emphasised again and again that their resistance would be non-violent, no matter what the other side did. And even when the state unleashed brutal and horrific violence on the protesters on July 20, Gen Z came back to the protest site the very same evening in greater numbers and remained there till Pradhan resigned.

Gen Z's refusal to back down reminded me of the Dandi march scene in *Gandhi*, where row after row of *satyagrahis* marched forward, braving police blows as they sought to enter the salt pans in defiance of the British. In the movie, an American reporter, played by Martin Sheen, begins his dispatch with: "They walked, both Hindu and Muslim alike, with heads held high, without any hope..." and ends with "...Whatever moral ascendancy the West held was lost here today."

Whatever last vestiges of morality the Modi government still laid claim to, were similarly lost on July 20.

Gandhi's credo was *satyagraha* – truth and non-violence. So is Gen Z's, as they have amply demonstrated, with the addition of some colourful language to communicate their *satya* more effectively.

Gen Z, at least in India, could be called Gen G (G for Gandhi).

The writer is an educator, author, and journalist.

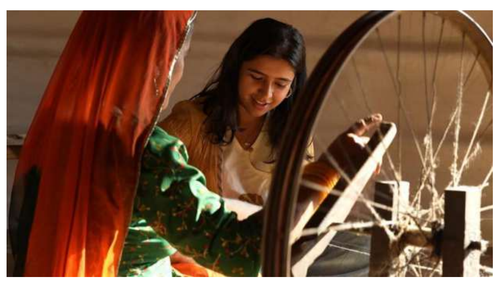


We have new colonisers in the country who look like us. So, [if Gandhi were a young Indian today] he would be opposing the same things he was opposing a century or so ago. He would be opposing extreme power, corruption, the condition of women. I live in Delhi, where all the protests are happening, and I believe Gandhi would be on the streets again now. But this time, though his message of non-violence worked very well at Jantar Mantar, I feel he would be a little louder, a little more rebellious.

KAANCHI CHOPRA, 27
Artist and designer

If Gandhi were a young Indian today, he might be deeply uncomfortable with the deteriorating civic sense and an apparently aimless education system. His ideas of simplicity and truth feel radical now, as we are losing these virtues rapidly. Ideas of non-violence and civil disobedience, though not outdated, aren't so radical, but the working population today can't afford a civil disobedience en masse. Gandhi gives this generation the concept of 'simplicity in sophistication' in a way few others have, but falls short in offering the kind of radical revolt figures like Bhagat Singh, Ambedkar, Periyar articulated to turn stones and crack nuts.

SHUBHAM KUMAR, 18
Student, IIT-Bombay

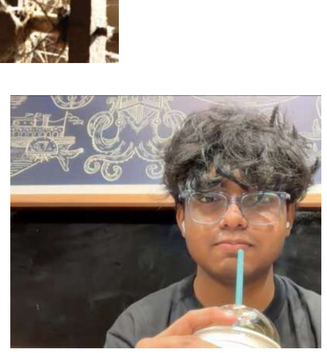


I think of Gandhi as someone who turned moral courage into political power. But the saint-like image is mostly something we inherit. He would probably dislike how India often mistakes growth for progress. Gen Z's speed, irony and online politics would confuse him. Truth and civil disobedience still feel radical because they require real courage. Simplicity feels less relevant today. Gandhi gives us restraint and mass mobilisation without hatred. But Ambedkar explains inequality and structural power much better.

NISARGA ADHIKARY, 19
Cybersecurity engineer, IIT-Kanpur

What the Father of the Nation would do if he were alive today, and what his life can still teach us

WHEN GEN Zs DON'T GIVE UP







What comes to me is the person, not the Mahatma. The image of his personality and resilience was handed down by our grandparents who were there during the freedom struggle. It's an extension of nostalgia. But, also, of my own readings of Gandhi over these years as a history student, reading his autobiography and Ramachandra Guha's books. While non-violence, simplicity, truth and civil disobedience are radical ideas, there are complex ideas of Gandhi [on gender, sexuality, and caste] which must be contested, debated, and criticised. People have to read and engage with Gandhi in order to criticise him. Gandhi, Ambedkar, Bhagat Singh, Periyar were all fighting in different ways for the same goal. One thing that reading Gandhi doesn't give you is the space for despair. The CJP protest showed that non-violent *satyagraha* can still be a useful tool. He remains our leader in spirit. At Karwaan, since 2019, we have tried to start dialogues of compassion, love and communal harmony.

ESHAN SHARMA, 26
Documentary filmmaker and founder of Karwaan Heritage, a student-led history collective



If alive today, Gandhi would have been uncomfortable with our obsession with instant results. In his time, things took patience and a lot of work before they came to life. He would want us to understand that the slow journey is what makes doing something great worthwhile. I think simplicity and choosing to live with less is radical today. Gandhi gives you the idea that restraint can be strength. He would have probably used social media platforms to spread his ideas of non-violence and civil disobedience. We don't need to make Gandhi 'cool', we need to make him relevant. Rap is a great way to get his message across to Gen Z.

ADIL KALYANPUR, OR A-KAL, 26
Professional tennis player and rapper

When I say no to "father of the nation" or "Mahatma," I'm not rejecting Gandhi as much as those very categories. The paternalism of one and the infallibility of the other are harmful. Gandhi had himself rebuffed at least one of them [the metaphorical fatherhood]. It's challenging to consider Gandhi's practice in an increasingly indifferent and broken world. That Gandhi was constantly inquisitive and uncertain about his own [famous and infamous] practices is lost on us, I think, and we might do well to read him more than only focus on his actions. Scholar and translator Rita Kothari once taught me in a class on Gandhi the importance of the question-answer form of his book *Hind Swaraj*; even in correspondence with others, he is posing and answering questions. That room for disagreement and questioning, for disagreement *because* one has carefully listened to someone, is rare and significant.

VIGHNESH HAMPAPURA, 27
Translator, writer, and Ph.D student

(As told to ***Tanushree Ghosh, Maitri Porecha, Surya Praphulla Kumar*** *and* ***Julie Merin Varughese****)*

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty





EYE OF THE ARTIST

Gandhi's abiding iconicity, from Nandalal Bose to Gigi Scaria

Neville Tuli

Our artistic imagery of Gandhi mostly begins with the aura of his relentless stamina and determination as he marches towards Dandi, where a man without weapon but a staff for balance, fearlessly fights against an infinite darkness with compassion and non-violence. Nandalal Bose made his iconic linocut of Gandhi in 1930 as he embarked on his Salt Satyagraha, becoming the first to lead a mass civil disobedience movement in India, even though Hungary and South Africa had witnessed civil disobedience earlier. Today, Gandhi lives in the protest.

Within the *satyagrahi*, his eternal significance and inspiration abides.

Over the years, virtually every artist has tried to express Gandhi's unique personality or his ideas with some creative insight.

He lived among us

During the heady 1930-40s, we saw Hemendranath Mazumdar ironically using the Western academic tradition of oil-on-canvas painting to arouse poignancy depicting Gandhi's arrest at Bombay's Mani Bhavan in 1932. And artist-journalist Chittaprosad's iconic graphic depiction of children transforming the street into a symbol of Quit India in 1942, even though the Communist Party of India, with which he was associated, opposed the movement. The famous photojournalist Henri Cartier-Bresson captured Gandhi's last days for a global audience, such as Bapu stepping out of the *dargah* of Sufi saint Bakhtiar Kaki in Delhi's Mehrauli with his grandnieces Abha and Manu shouldering him with care on January 27, 1948. All these images created that magnificent visual base of a noble existence.

In 1969, on Gandhi's birth centenary celebrations, we saw Anil Sengupta's brilliantly expressive series of 30 images narrating Bapu's life using colour, line and dynamic compositions to remind the public of his inspirational life.

By 1982, the world was being inspired by his unique legacy and life, as seen in the Polish poster of the film *Gandhi*, in a land where Lech Walesa's 'Solidarity' movement had begun barely a few years earlier.











(Clockwise from far left) Mahatma Gandhi, Kasturba and Rabindranath Tagore with others at Santiniketan, February 1940; Anil Sengupta's lithograph, 1969; *Bapuji on Dandi March* (1930) by Nandalal Bose; Polish poster of Richard Attenborough's film *Gandhi*, by Maciej Woltman; *Who Deviated First?*, artwork by Gigi Scaria; and Chittaprosad's 'Quit India 1942' linocut. (COURTESY TULI RESEARCH CENTRE FOR INDIA STUDIES)

Follow, unfollow

As the Gen-Z age unfolded, with an increasing questioning of Gandhi's relevance, as it must be with all great legacies wishing to continue meaningfully, many new creative interpretations have emerged.

Contemporary artist Gigi Scaria's *Who Deviated First?* was the finest example of this turn of perception. Taking *Gyarah Murti*, Debiprosad Roy Chowdhury's iconic commissioned sculpture at Sardar Patel Marg, as the historic foundation, Scaria posed the question: who is following Gandhi today? Have they all turned away in other directions or failed to keep up the march on the terms that non-violence, compassion and idealism demand?

Yet this questioning is critical, for all truth lies in the 'question-answer-question' continuity. Gandhi's vision of a full life, embracing all facets in one's search for truth, albeit risking many omissions and blind spots, is an enduring inspiration for all living souls. The artistic fraternity will always rise with loving and critical eyes to do justice to his meaningful existence.

The writer is the founder and trustee of The Tuli Research Centre for India Studies



A still from Cynthia Lukas's documentary *Kasturba Gandhi: Accidental Activist* (2023).

BINGE WATCH

Beyond the biopic

Documentaries and podcasts show us the Mahatma we don't know

Earlier this year, ahead of an interview with the historian Rajmohan Gandhi, I read his excellent book *James Lawson: Teacher of Satyagraha*. The book's subject James Lawson (1928-2024) was an American professor and civil rights activist who studied Gandhian resistance in Pune in the 1950s, and returned to America to apply those non-violent methods to the civil rights movement alongside Martin Luther King Jr.

He organised *satyagraha*-like sit-ins at Vanderbilt University, Tennessee, and later wrote at length about how Gandhi inspired this strategy, calling him "one of the most creative political leaders of all time". There are so many lesser-known aspects of Mahatma Gandhi's life that even otherwise well-informed Indians are not aware of.

Since the days of Richard Attenborough's *Gandhi* or Shyam Benegal's *Making of the Mahatma*, directors have kept reinventing Gandhi on screen. Sudhir Mishra's forthcoming historical film will see Manoj Bajpayee reprise Bapu, and Pratik Gandhi essays the Mahatma from plays (*Mohan No Masalo*) to web-series (Hansal Mehta's upcoming OTT series). But popular feature films can only do so much. That's where history books and documentary films can fill the gap.

Past the familiar

To that end, Rajmohan Gandhi (the Mahatma's grandson) and James Lawson are both interviewed in the excellent documentary *Ahimsa – Gandhi: Power of the Powerless* (2021), directed by Ramesh Sharma.

In the film, Rajmohan says, "[Mahatma] Gandhi saw the horror of violence in South Africa. And he realised the need for something with which to fight it without inviting a horrible retribution [upon the oppressed]. It occurred to him that a non-violent struggle could be the way – but it had to be absolutely fearless, you had to be prepared to pay the full price."

Veteran documentarian Sharma, known for the Shashi Kapoor-Om Puri political thriller *New Delhi Times* (1986), on Delhi media's ethics and corruption, balances the talking-heads exposition with rare archival footage of Gandhi in the documentary.

At the 2026 Mumbai International Film Festival (MIFF), audiences were treated to a restored version of the 1968 documentary *Mahatma: Life of Gandhi* (1869-1948), directed by Vithalbai Jhaveri, the late writer, photographer, freedom fighter and filmmaker. Restored under the government's National Film Heritage Mission (NFHM) initiative, the film documents crucial moments from the Mahatma's life, including the 1930 Dandi March.

Another noteworthy documentary is American filmmaker and producer Cynthia Lukas's *Kasturba Gandhi: Accidental Activist* (2023). Narrated by actor Naveen Andrews, it's the first of a three-part non-fiction series which seeks to present an independent history of Kasturba's life and activism, not merely placing her as a conduit for the Mahatma's efforts. PBS (Public Broadcasting Service) is planning to broadcast the second installment, *Kasturba Gandhi: Compassionate Activist*, in March 2027 for Women's History Month.

Make it clickable

For audiences accustomed to YouTube and Spotify, they may not exactly be flocking to PBS or NPR. They seek – if at all – fast, clickable information, laced with irony and internet-specific humour. If your brain is wired this way, there are some excellent new Gandhi-related histories you can dip into. The popular YouTube channel History After Dark released a Gandhi documentary last year: *Gandhi: The Most Dangerous Pacifist in Human History*. It was very well-received among American audiences because it does an excellent job of condensing the big, influential moments in Gandhi's life. But in its second half, it also provides us with some of the edgier, more controversial aspects of the man's belief system, including his views on caste, race and sexuality.

Another excellent online resource in this context is the 2024 podcast *Gandhi – The Beginning*, where veteran journalist Ashraf Engineer sat down with writer-activist Tushar Gandhi (the Mahatma's great-grandson and founder-president of Mahatma Gandhi Foundation in Vadodara) for a tête-à-tête on Gandhi's family history and formative years in South Africa. Together, they unpack the basic elements of the Mahatma's ideology, and how he arrived at his most well-known and unshakeable political-moral convictions. The podcast is based on a memoir by the Mahatma's secretary Pyarelal who recorded minutes for Gandhi's meetings in the 1920s and 1930s.

In 1947, in the newspaper he edited, *Harijan*, Gandhi wrote: "In a democratic scheme, money invested in the promotion of learning gives a tenfold return to the people even as a seed sown in good soil returns a luxuriant crop." Let these documentaries and podcasts fortify or challenge what you make of the man behind the Mahatma.



Aditya Mani Jha is working on his first book of non-fiction.

PERSON OF INTEREST

SUJATA SAWANT: AT YOUR SERVICE

This community activist is cutting through caste and religion in a Mumbai slum



Sujata Sawant's Adarsh Foundation operates a community kitchen and a study centre in Mumbai. (EMMANUAL YOGINI)

In another life, Sujata Sawant, 49, was an accountant with a salary and Sundays off. She plunged into politics in 2014 during the Legislative Assembly election in Maharashtra as a worker of the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), drawn in through an informally adopted brother.

She began working part-time in Mumbai's Kurla constituency, and that's when Sawant first visited a hamlet in Qureshi Nagar, a 25-year-old settlement, almost entirely Muslim and migrant, a forgotten slum sliced by the railway line. Home to daily-wage workers and with a high-school dropout rate of 95%, it would go on to become the centre of her life's work.

You could describe her as a social worker, a community leader or a former party worker. "I joined politics because of [BSP leader] Mayawati but at the grassroots level, most men can't handle women functionaries," she says, adding that the party's fiery promises to the poorest soon began to falter. "I understood that politics is all talk and no action." But Sawant couldn't move past the hunger and desperation she had seen. She quit her comfortable job and signed up to be a social worker with a non-profit in the neighbourhood.

In 2016, a disillusioned Sawant quit the non-profit and began Adarsh Foundation, which runs a study centre and community kitchen. A decade on, standup comic Varun Grover has become a firm supporter, helping her crowdsource funds. Recently, Grover and two other comedians, Gaurav Gupta and Gaurav Kapoor, pledged their joint ₹12.5 lakh winnings on game show *Kaun Banega Crorepati* to Sawant. Yet, Sawant can't rest. She's already worrying about where the next thousand meals will come from.

She's a comet, she's a hero

Her heroes are Ambedkar and Savitribai Phule. Her work embodies Gandhi's idea of truth through service, while also laying the groundwork for an Ambedkar-style social democracy. Her method is deceptively simple: "Continuous work with honesty." None of this, however, offers even a glimpse of her daily struggle to raise funds. If you send her money, you can expect an immediate receipt, with a beautifully worded 'thank you' note.

I think of her as a comet, tearing through barriers of caste and religion as she hurtles through life. In popular culture, heroes are usually male and upper class – Sawant, a Buddhist who wears saris these days, turns this idea on its head.

When Sawant first started talking about empowerment and education in Qureshi Nagar – where mothers stayed home, cared for children and everyone did piecework, earning ₹1 per shirt to cut extra threads or sew buttons on it – there were few takers. "People needed money, from anywhere, to pay rent," she says. "Nobody cared about education, healthy eating or what they should wear."

For the conservative Muslim residents, Sawant's *bindaas* (carefree), voluble demeanour and casual clothes (*kurta* and tights or jeans) were a shock. "They would say, 'she doesn't even wear a *dupatta*, how will she keep our daughters *barkarar* (intact)?' The religious barriers were very strong," she says. The first few times she tried to get women together for a self-help group or to apply for a government scheme, only a handful showed up.

"I realised there were many children who wanted to make something of their life," says Sawant. "For local leaders, they were just a vote bank." She started a study centre and organised the women. Politician and columnist Sudheendra Kulkarni was an early benefactor. Sawant and the women tried everything from making fish nets for home aquariums to manufacturing sanitary pads and running a food stall at the local RTO.

Hand that feeds many

During the pandemic, everything collapsed, and the focus turned to feeding people. Non-profit Khaana Chahiye Foundation helped and Sawant distributed 8,000 meal packets a day. In the second wave, the women started making the food themselves.

Over the years, Sawant has waged many battles for children who are married off as soon as they hit puberty, or forced to work from an early age, and sometimes trapped in addiction simply to stave off hunger. In addition to the 328 children enrolled at her study centre, Sawant feeds another 150 people every day – single or divorced women, senior citizens, people with disabilities, and those who have been abandoned. "Only if your stomach is full can you do anything else," she says. Today, Sawant is a firm insider, everyone's sister: *tai*, *aapa* and *didi*.

By 2018, the dropout rate in Qureshi Nagar had fallen to 5%. Sawant's foundation was among those selected for the 'Best Antyoday Practise' award by the Indian Social Responsibility Network. The real reward, though, has been having a ringside seat to change. As the women began buying into her ideas, they braved the displeasure at home and pushed their children to study. Stanford and IIT-Bombay have both researched parts of this slum's journey.

Over the years, Sawant's study centre has birthed an engineer, a pathologist, an event manager, and a karate champ. In 2016, the first three children to pass Class X were all girls, two of them sisters. Sawant helped the siblings withstand marriage pressure and overcome an acid-attack threat for continuing their education. Today, they are nurses and own a flat. Sawant likes to call them a miracle, just one of many she has helped create.



***Priya Ramani** is a Bengaluru-based journalist and the co-founder of India Love Project on Instagram.*

GOREN BRIDGE

Bad luck?

Both vulnerable, North deals

Bob Jones

Routine auction, where South's three-club bid gave North a chance to show three-card spade support. The defense started with three rounds of hearts, South ruffing the third. South led a diamond to the king. Had West held the ace of diamonds, South could develop a club discard on a diamond. East won with the ace and led a trump. South won in dummy with the king of spades and led a spade to his jack. He then started on clubs. This would have succeeded if the clubs split 3-3 or if the player with only two clubs was out of trumps. He could then ruff his fourth club in dummy. West, however, ruffed the third round of clubs and the contract was defeated.

South could have done better. This was another overlooked dummy reversal. After he led a spade to the jack, he should have led a diamond to dummy's queen and ruffed a diamond. He should then cross back to dummy with a club and ruff dummy's remaining diamond with his last trump. Another club to dummy would allow him to draw the last trump and make his contract. This line would fail if an opponent with a doubleton club could discard one on the fourth diamond, but then the contract was never makable. Too bad.

NORTH
♠ K Q 7
♡ K 5 2
◇ K Q 8 6
♣ K Q 10

WEST
♠ 6 5 2
♡ Q J 10 6
◇ J 9 5 3
♣ 8 6

EAST
♠ 8 3
♡ A 8 7 4
◇ A 10 4
♣ J 9 7 4

SOUTH
♠ A J 10 9 4
♡ 9 3
◇ 7 2
♣ A 5 3 2

The bidding:

NORTH	EAST	SOUTH	WEST
1◇	Pass	1♠	Pass
2NT	Pass	3♣	Pass
3♠	Pass	4♠	All pass

Opening lead: Queen of ♡

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

All about sisters rising

Berty Ashley

1 Born on October 4, 1862, Johanna Gezina was a Dutch teacher, editor and translator who became an important promoter of her brother-in-law's art. After his death, she worked to establish his reputation, while her son, Vincent Willem, eventually founded a museum dedicated to his uncle. Whose sister-in-law was she?

2 Dorothy loved taking long walks with her brother William, and recording her observations in her journal. On one such walk, they encountered a field of daffodils, which inspired one of William's most famous poems. Dorothy's journals were not published during her lifetime, but her brother went on to global fame. What was her full name?

3 Maria Anna was a child prodigy on the keyboard from the age of seven. Her harpsichord playing inspired her younger brother Wolfgang, and the two toured Europe together as musical prodigies. As she grew older, social conventions restricted her professional career, although she taught and performed. What was their family name?

4 Katharine was a teacher in Dayton, Ohio, and helped her elder brothers run their bicycle shop while they experimented with flight. She handled correspondence, communications and public relations, and nursed Orville back to health after his 1908 crash. In 1909, she accompanied her brothers to Europe, helped promote their aviation business and became the first woman invited to a meeting of the Aéro-Club de France. What was her full name?



Vijaya Lakshmi Pandit was the first woman to preside over the United Nations General Assembly. (GETTY IMAGES)

5 Caroline Herschel and her brother William were astronomers, and she went on to discover eight comets. On March 13, 1781, William was observing the night sky with a telescope from his home in Bath when he spotted what he initially thought was a comet. Later observations established it as a new planet. Which planet did he discover?

6 Vijaya Lakshmi Pandit was imprisoned multiple times for her participation in India's freedom struggle. She later became the first woman to preside over the United Nations General Assembly. She was also elected to the first Lok Sabha of independent India in 1952. Who was her brother, who became the first Prime Minister of the Republic of India?

7 Eunice Mary was an American philanthropist who founded the Special Olympics. She also played important roles in the political campaigns of her brothers John, Robert and Edward, speaking at events and helping with fundraising. What was her family name, one of America's best-known political dynasties?

8 Maya Soetoro-Ng is an Indonesian-American academic and an associate at the Spark M. Matsunaga Institute for Peace and Conflict Resolution. She has an older half-brother who was born in Hawaii and spent part of his childhood in Jakarta with their mother. He later made political history, and Maya participated in his campaigns. Who was her half-brother?

9 Fatima was among the earliest women to qualify as a dentist in British India, graduating in 1923. After her elder brother's wife's death, she gave up her dental practice to care for his household. Her memoir *My Brother* was published after his death. Who was her brother, the founder of Pakistan?

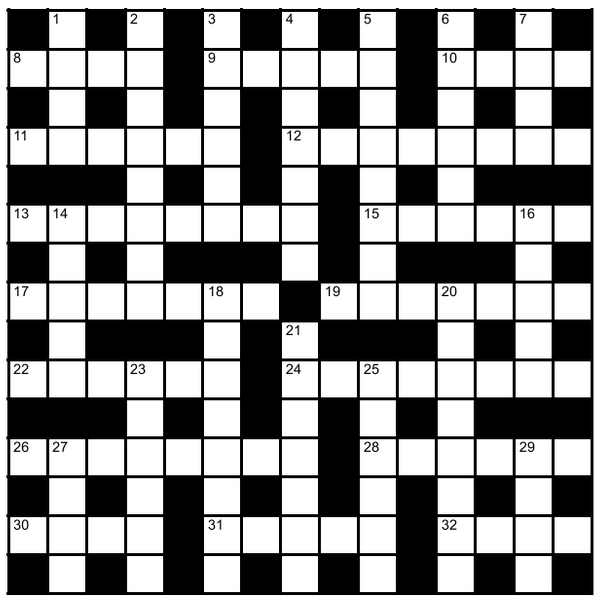
10 Sophia Brahe worked with her brother Tycho Brahe, helping to maintain detailed astronomical observations. Their precise measurements of planetary positions, particularly those of Mars, later proved invaluable to Johannes Kepler. Using this data, Kepler overturned the prevailing assumption that planets moved in perfect circles. What did he discover about the shape of planetary orbits?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

Answers

1. Vincent Van Gogh
2. Dorothy Wordsworth
3. Mozart
4. Katherine Wright
5. Uranus
6. Jawaharlal Nehru
7. Kennedy
8. Barack Obama
9. Muhammad Ali Jinnah
10. Elliptical orbits, not circular

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 76 (Set by Incognito)



Across

8 Letter from Tibet arrived (4)
9 Engineers mentioned in the number (5)
10 One leaves heavenly female in 60 minutes (4)
11 Some Middle Easterners and European soldiers follow Yankee at institute (6)
12 Acacia, for example, from one door now being repaired (8)
13 Left university girl in European country (8)
15 Take for short time old Rolls Royce parked in front of ship (6)
17 Horribly cursed a second hand automobile (4-3)
19 Hoped snake with anger died (7)
22 Accompany from Spanish court after discarding uniform (6)
24 For example, Paddy and Rishi strangely manage in absence of time (8)
26 After middle of night, excitedly pour champagne, for example, at first for musical band (3,5)
28 Wrongly buries precious stones (6)
30 Consumed after soft mincemeat (4)
31 Rise and dress (3,2)
32 Colour bird carrying a piece of nut (4)

Down

1 Give away editor hiding in church (4)
2 Secured legal right to place temporary accommodation next to Father Edward (8)
3 Group following saint to get packing material (6)
4 Dotty communication from superb rail leaflet (7)
5 Engineers with scepticism starting to scrap fortifications (8)
6 One who displays a bathroom fitting (6)
7 Embrace with love, the author of The Hunchback of Notre-Dame (4)
14 Individual leaving fertile spot around Middle Eastern kilns (5)
16 Final letter from Santhome garrison (5)
18 Like hats 7 manufactured (2,6)
20 Lives in horrible sin, possessing addictive practice (8)
21 Can spot damaged metal vessels (7)
23 Wild parties from Oregon soldiers having Ecstacy (6)
25 In absence of net, wrongly interrupt and intrude (6)
27 Major Albert's hiding a sort of test (4)
29 Bird from other nest (4)

SOLUTION NO. 75

L	■	E	■	B	■	A	■	P	■	V	■	H	■	T
O	W	N	G	O	A	L	■	A	N	A	T	O	M	Y
G	■	T	■	M	■	I	■	N	■	M	■	T	■	P
G	R	O	W	B	A	G	■	D	E	P	L	E	T	E
I	■	M	■	■	■	H	■	E	■	I	■	L	■	C
A	R	B	O	R	E	T	U	M	■	R	A	I	T	A
■	■	■	E	■	■	■	■	I	■	E	■	E	■	S
O	U	T	F	L	O	W	■	C	A	B	A	R	E	T
L	■	E	■	A	■	I	■	■	■	A	■	■	■	■
D	E	L	F	T	■	S	W	E	E	T	S	P	O	T
G	■	E	■	I	■	H	■	N	■	■	■	I	■	U
U	N	C	I	V	I	L	■	M	U	F	F	L	E	R
A	■	A	■	E	■	I	■	I	■	U	■	E	■	K
R	E	S	E	L	L	S	■	T	O	N	S	U	R	E
D	■	T	■	Y	■	T	■	Y	■	D	■	P	■	Y

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In step An Oppana performance at a school arts festival in Kozhikode. (K. RAGESH)

Age-old synergy, vibrant rhythms

As Islam took root in Malabar and the community integrated elements of Arab culture into their own practices, unique art forms such as Oppana brightened the cultural landscape

The first time I watched Oppana, a folk dance of the Malabar region of Kerala, I was simply left captivated. What is most fascinating about this group dance by women is its history.

It is believed to have started as a form of entertainment by the women of the Mappila community. Origin of Mappilas, or Muslims settled in northern Kerala, goes back to medieval times, when there was a flourishing trade relationship between the Arab world and Kerala, based on spice trade.

Due to various factors such as weather, political turmoil or travel constraints, Arab traders were at times forced to stay back for short periods in the coastal areas of Malabar. Over generations, their association with the local population gave rise to the Mappila community.

As Islam took root in Malabar and the community integrated elements of Arab culture into its own practices, unique art forms such as Oppana sprang up, and that is perhaps one of the most beautiful expressions of that cultural meeting. The rhythmic clapping, gentle movements, vibrant attire, and music makes Oppana one of the most vibrant and expressive folk dance forms of Malabar, carrying traces of this long cultural journey. It is believed that the word Oppana signifies singing and rhythmic clapping.

Adaptation and transformation

Oppana slowly underwent a process of adaptation and transformation, incorporating new musical styles, choreographic techniques, and thematic motifs. The dance form absorbed influences from indigenous traditions such as Thiruvathirakkali, performed by Hindu women, resulting in a unique fusion of Arab and Malayali aesthetics.

It was during a school art festival in Kannur district of Kerala that I got a chance to see young girls perform Oppana on the stage. The festival is Asia's largest school arts festival and is a much-awaited competitive annual event organised by the Kerala government to preserve and promote growth of various art forms including classical dances, music, drama, painting, and tribal art forms. Many Malayalam film stars such as Manju Warrier and Kavya Madhavan are products of this festival.

Oppana is traditionally associated with weddings, and is fun-based aimed at teasing the young bride. It was simply a delight to watch a beautifully dressed bride adorned in gorgeous gold ornaments sitting on a high-seat *peedam* wearing *mylanchi*, or henna, on her palms, ankles, and feet. Other performing women were dressed in traditional Kerala Muslim attire and they formed a circle around the bride, clapping their hands in a simple rhythmic movement.

It started slowly with the bride's friends walking in with her, singing lines of a prayer song named *Bismiyum Hamdum*. It soon caught pace and moved onto fast rhythmical steps.

Brightly coloured attire worn by performers included a long-sleeved blouse known as *jubba* with a scarf called *thattam* paired with a flowing skirt called a *kaachimundu*, enhancing its visual appeal.

Oppana songs are called Mappilappaattu (songs of Mappila) revolving around themes of love, romance, and devotion.

Sung in an interactive format, they evoke a range of emotions, from longing and passion to jubilation and ecstasy. Each Mappilappaattu has a unique rhythmic style, which is called *Ishal*, akin to Hindustani music's *tal* and *raga*. *Ishal* carries a strong influence of folk songs of Kerala and Arabian musical traditions. Mappilappaattus are generally written in Arabimalayalam, which is the unique community language of Mappilas, meaning writing oral Malayalam by using Arabic and modified Arabic letters. Arabimalayalam has borrowed words from many languages such as Malayalam, Arabic, Tamil, Persian, and Tulu.

Therefore, Mappilappaattu has Tamil, Persian, and Arabic words. Songs are often accompanied by musical instruments such as harmonium, ganjira, tabla, and *elathaalam* (cymbals).

> **Oppana is traditionally associated with weddings,** and is fun-based, aimed at teasing the young bride. It starts slowly with the bride's friends walking in with her, singing lines of a prayer song named *Bismiyum Hamdum*. It soon catches pace and shifts to fast rhythmical steps

Resilient cultural expression

Despite the vicissitudes of history, Oppana persisted as a resilient and enduring form of cultural expression, maintaining its relevance and vitality within Kerala's cultural landscape.

In contemporary times, Oppana continues to thrive as a vibrant expression of Kerala's cultural heritage, transcending geographical boundaries and captivating audiences worldwide.

Oppana has now found new avenues for expression in cultural events, festivals, and competitions, continuing to inspire and delight audiences with its beauty, grace, and emotional resonance.

Cycling is a way of life for the Dutch

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Nearly three decades ago, I arrived in the Netherlands on a three-year assignment. My first impressions are still fresh in my mind. After landing at Amsterdam's Schiphol Airport, walking past rows of swanky shops packed with luxury goods and going down just one level to catch a train, I immediately understood why it was considered one of the world's best-designed airports in one of the most modern countries.

But the view from the train window surprised me with rural scenes. Instead of tall skyscrapers and sprawling malls, I saw wide green pastures where cows, goats, and horses were grazing; old windmills turning lazily in the distance; and small, scattered houses which could be reached only by narrow paths. Later, my hotel in The Hague – with its luxurious rooms, a casino, and an Olympic-sized swimming pool on the rooftop – reminded me that this was indeed a modern country. That evening, a sight from my hotel room puzzled me. Men, women, and children were all moving about on bicycles – a mode of transport that, back home, was largely associated with the poor. The next morning, a Monday, I stepped out of my hotel and noticed a strange scene – a man unloading three bicycles from the back of his sleek car. He, along with a woman and a child, took the bicycles and parked them. A short while later, the man, dressed in a coat, suit, and tie, drove away. Only then did I begin to understand the Dutch way of life: a balance of health and wealth.

A week later, as soon as we moved into our home, I bought three bicycles – one for my wife, one for our daughter, and one for myself. We discovered the joy of simple living through cycling.

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On a recent trip to Europe, we saw, in almost all the cities we had visited, drivers stopping mid-traffic to let pedestrians cross. This is in stark contrast to what we see in India. Here, navigating the roads is a real challenge for the pedestrians. The second you get behind the wheel, your driving licence loses its legal weight and effectively becomes a waiver – a gentle reminder that the universe has absolved itself of all liability the moment you pull into traffic.

First, let us talk about traffic sense – or rather, its complete and glorious absence. In India, lane markings are less rule than rumour, treated not as boundaries but as artistic suggestions from a civil engineer who was clearly dreaming of a better country.

Straddling the exact centre of two lanes is standard technique, guaranteeing that nobody behind you can overtake.

Then there is the sacred ritual of continuous honking. Elsewhere in the world, a horn is reserved for genuine emergencies. In India, it is an acoustic extension of the driver's soul, deployed to express joy, rage, existential dread, or simply to announce, "I exist, therefore I honk." Drivers honk at red lights, honk in traffic jams going nowhere, and honk at stationary trees and park benches – in case the trees decide to wander into the road. The noise is relentless enough that visitors to Bengaluru regularly complain about it; one Japanese tourist fled straight back to his hotel, unable to take it any longer.



No room If you are a pedestrian trying to cross the street, may the odds be ever in your favour. (GETTY IMAGES/ ISTOCK)

The unscripted combat sport called Indian traffic

Surviving a daily commute calls for a rare blend of supernatural reflexes, total fearlessness, and an unwavering faith in divine intervention

Designated targets

If you are a pedestrian trying to cross the street, may the odds be ever in your favour. Zebra crossings function less as safe zones and more as designated targets. Slowing down for a pedestrian is viewed by fellow motorists as a sign of deep moral weakness. In fact, whenever we try to cross the roads, the oncoming vehicles increase their speed to prevent you from crossing the road. The pedestrian, well drilled in this ritual, responds with a panicked sprint graceful enough to qualify for the Olympics.

Red traffic lights present another fascinating psychological study. Officially, a red light means "stop". Unofficially, it means "stop, unless there is no traffic constable in sight".

An empty intersection at a red light is taken as a personal insult to an Indian driver's sense of efficiency. Standing still with no cross-traffic in sight is considered an unpardonable waste of fuel and momentum. Red lights, in practice, function as polite suggestions rather than instructions.

Ultimately, surviving a daily commute in India calls for a rare blend of supernatural reflexes, total fearlessness, and unwavering faith in divine intervention. You do not simply drive to your destination – you survive a trial by fire and arrive faintly astonished that all four wheels made the journey with you.

A friend of mine who works in Dubai was once refused a driving licence there. He protested that he had been driving in India for over 30 years. The inspector's reply was withering: "Sir, you have been moving cars. You have not been driving." He may have had a point.

India still has no law imposing serious fines for needless honking, and we all know how driving licences get handed out here. It is high time stringent tests were introduced before anyone is let loose behind a wheel.

FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

The growing attention to chronic inflammation is useful, but public discussion should remain evidence-based. ('Everything is inflammation now'; Sept. 27) Wellness influencers often simplify complex medical issues. Greater awareness should encourage people to seek qualified medical advice rather than follow fashionable remedies.
A. Myilsami

Worthy of attention

Uma Mahadevan-Dasgupta's review emphasises the importance of introducing India's unique literary works to the world. ('Reading India'; Sept. 27) The book is a commendable effort towards bringing global attention to Indian regional works.
Rabeeh Cheruppa

Literary exchange

More works should be translated directly between Indian languages, not only into English. ('Flight of the bumblebee'; Sept. 27) Public libraries, universities and publishers can collaborate to make quality translations affordable and widely available.
Prajesh Paramasivan

Elephant in the room

The author's criticism of the government, including his pointed questions to the Prime Minister and Finance Minister, should be viewed as an expression of his political opinion rather than the whole picture. ('About that 'free' UPI'; Sept. 27) The concerns of ordinary users and small merchants deserve attention, but the debate should also consider the government's stated rationale and the actual impact of the revised fee structure.
Pon. Arun Kumar

No room for drama

The humorous take on customised media kits also raises a practical question about public events: communication and hospitality should remain purposeful and practical. ('My personal BRICS goodie bag'; Sept. 27) Clear guidelines on gifts and event-related materials would avoid unnecessary extravagance and confusion.
S.M. Jeeva

Age no bar

The article humorously exposes the tendency to treat old age as a reason to withdraw from active life. ('Age of recline'; Sept. 27) Age should not determine whether a person runs, travels, socialises or simply enjoys new experiences. Families should encourage older people to remain active.
K. Sakunthala

Rich textile heritage

Indian chintz and *kalamkari* travelled far beyond their places of origin, adapting to local tastes while retaining their craftsmanship. ('Checks, chintz and cultural crossings'; Sept 27) Such shared histories deserve wider documentation and preservation.
S.P. Suganya Devi

Support system

The tenderness with which Saba Mahjoor remembers Phuphee and the unexpected comfort extended by Fiona make the piece much more than a personal recollection. ('The women who held me'; Sept. 27) It becomes a beautiful reflection on the quiet ways in which women hold one another through difficult times.
Sajna Hameed

MORE ON THE WEB

www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page

For the love of languages
Being a polyglot has its advantages
Lakshmi R. Srinivas

Vanishing act at 'The Met'
A day at the Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York
Anand Simha

Consistency, thy name is love?
Do not hesitate to love, even if it needs commitment and consistency
Viji Narayan

The neighbourhood news hub
The barbershop is a cut above when it comes to debating happenings in the village
Rinu J. George

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(Clockwise from left) The Saptamatrikas at *Garden of Gestures*; globes inspired by the ones Swali saw in the Vatican's archives with disfigured continents, stitched by women who were never taught what the world looked like; Swali with Maria Grazia Chiuri in front of a map of Mumbai; and *Belong* at Experimenter. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

Women, both divine and real, run through all three exhibitions celebrating 40 years of Chanakya International

GODDESSES IN THE EVERYDAY

Shweta Shiware

Chanakya International turns 40 and refuses nostalgia: no parade of old collections, no greatest-hits montage of their collaborations with over 50 fashion houses, artists and institutions. Instead, the textile and embroidery house founded by Vinod Shah, with its School of Craft now 10, marks both anniversaries across three Mumbai venues.

Deep inside its Byculla atelier, in an enclosed grove called Kunj, fibre falls from ceiling to floor around a 9th-century stone Varahi, a boar-headed goddess. She belongs to the family, and has been "a massive source of inspiration" for Karishma Swali, Shah's daughter and creative director of Chanakya International. Nearly two decades ago, while cataloguing the family's antiquities, Swali found Indus seals stamped with seven female figures and wondered who they were. They were the Saptamatrikas, or Seven Mothers.

The legacy that Shah built

Women, both divine and real, run through all three exhibitions. At the atelier, *Garden of Gestures* sets seven goddesses in red raffia among workshop tools, tracing how skill passes from one hand to another. At the Dr. Bhau Daji Lad Museum, *En Route* turns to real women, six adventurers in particular, asking how knowledge travels. At Experimenter in Colaba, *Belong* brings the goddesses back in plain fibre to consider what we carry with us.

When Shah founded Chanakya in 1986, he invited craftspeople from across India to Mumbai. "He's an artist and aesthete. His idea was simple: to share India's finest craftsmanship with the world," Swali says. His first client, she recalls, was Italian designer Alberta Ferretti. In their early 20s, Swali and her brother Nehal took four suitcases of swatches to Italy and approached 400 fashion houses; only one, Fendi, signed on.

Since then, Chanakya has grown and now Shah, 83, worries about his 49-year-old daughter's pace. "He wants me to rest," she laughs. But 30 years in, she does the opposite. "I feel an urgency to learn more, to learn quickly."

'I feel women are long-limbed'

Garden of Gestures at the Byculla atelier is laid out as groves from ancient texts, each a stage in learning a craft. Visitors enter Upvan, the garden brought close, lined with tools, natural dyes, fabric scraps, and photos of hands at work. Next comes Tapovan, the forest of contemplation. At its heart, the Saptamatrikas stand in a red arc, taller than a doorway. The Matrikas' bodies are date-palm raffia dyed with madder root, bamboo and cotton cord.

Vaishnavi's vast bell of a skirt narrows to a fragile torso; Maheshvari turns architectural, trident raised; Varahi swells at the waist; Narasimhi rides a crocheted tree trunk; Brahmi, the tallest at 2.6 metres, rises in a narrow column; Indrani holds a lotus and a curved blade. Macramé flares out in Chamunda's skirt; flames rise from her head, yet the fiercest mother looks gentle here.

All seven are long-limbed, a trait that runs through Swali's practice. "I feel women are long-limbed – just the idea of being able to carry so much, hold so much, transmit so much," she says. The proportions are hers, but 25 artisans from the School built the bodies, dividing faces, hands and torsos before assembling figures larger than anything they'd ever made.

The city in thread

Five minutes from the atelier, the Dr. Bhau Daji Lad Museum, the city's oldest (formerly, the Victoria and Albert Museum), turns to Mumbai itself. *En Route* opens in the green-and-gold atrium with a freestanding map of the island city, stitched in seven layers of thread. It floats in pale lilac water, looped with black routes and flecked with pennants as it charts the city from the seven islands once known as Heptanesia through reclamation, trade, shipping and cotton mills to the Art Deco seafront. The piece draws on the museum's rare maps, which its honorary director, Tasneem Zakaria Mehta, invited Swali to study.

Upstairs, in salmon-pink galleries, hang works shown at the Vatican in 2025, now in India for the first time. Swali made them with Italian designer Maria Grazia Chiuri, who brought Chanakya's embroidery to Dior's women's collections as creative director between 2016 and 2025, and backed the School's collaborations with artists such as Judy Chicago.

Invited by the Vatican Apostolic Library to make work for the Catholic Jubilee year, the pair found books by 19th-century women travellers in its archives. Four linen and hemp panels, held together with *kantha*, now trace six of their journeys, among them journalist Nellie Bly, writer Gertrude Bell, and Annie Londonderry, the first woman to cycle around the world.

The mothers, pared back

By the time you reach Experimenter, the mothers have shed colour and ornament. *Belong* is Chanakya School's second solo with Prateek and Priyanka Raja's gallery. Now, the goddesses are handwoven from jute, coconut and banana fibre. Swali calls them *stambhs*: "pillar-like, like the trees of the forest".

Seven also become nine, with some mothers repeated. At the centre stands Brahmi, her four faces looking in every direction, flanked by two lion-headed Narasimhis. Maheshvari appears thrice, Vaishnavi twice and Varahi once; Indrani and Chamunda remain absent.

Even off their pedestals, the mothers are watching. On one wall hangs *Within*, three embroidered panels of dense foliage. Look closely and eyes peer out between the leaves; Prateek says Swali thinks of them as the Saptamatrikas.

For him, what matters is who made all of this. "It's fascinating to see how they develop these forms and how collectively women work together in making these come alive," he says. For Swali, there is no line between the goddesses and the women who made them. "We are them, right? And they are us."

En Route is at Dr. Bhau Daji Lad Museum till October 20, and Belong *at Experimenter till October 17.*

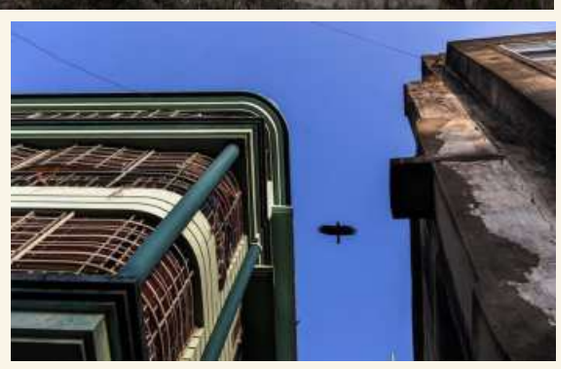
The writer is a columnist and critic, with a keen focus on fashion, textiles, and culture.

Seamus Murphy's poetic realism

Be it in conflict zones or domestic settings, the Irish photographer's career-spanning show conveys both humour and humanism









(Clockwise from left) Photographs shot in Kabul, Afghanistan in 2002 and 1994; the photographer; Ritchie Road, Kolkata, 2023; and Irkutsk Oblast, Russia, 2008. (SEAMUS MURPHY)



Nidhi Gupta

It takes Seamus Murphy a long moment to answer when I ask him to pick a single photograph from his new show. One image, out of four decades of work, that a first-time visitor should stand in front of. "It's very hard," he says, slightly perplexed. "I don't think you can sum it up in one image, I'm afraid." Then he lands on one anyway: a family in Kabul, photographed in their home in 1994, that he has returned to, again and again, for 30 years.

In 1994, on a dangerous frontline, he stayed with the Ba Deli family – a father and four sons. He photographed them, and has been photographing them periodically, whenever he can travel to Afghanistan. To him, their ordinary yet extraordinary lives, lived under invasion after occupation, filled with death, birth and marriage, is as much "a barometer of how the country has suffered, evolved and is suffering again now" as the triptych of photographs of Jade Maiwand, a thoroughfare in Kabul built in 1948, that he has photographed repeatedly, from the same vantage point, over his 20 visits to the country.

These photographs hold the sort of intimacy and poetic realism that the London-based Irish photographer and filmmaker has been seeking across his career. And they surface repeatedly at his new exhibition, *Life is in Many Days*, at the Museo Camera in Gurugram. A career-spanning show that sheds light on his stellar journey with documentary photography, it gathers work from Afghanistan, Ireland, Kolkata, Russia and the U.S.

The show, curated by author-editor Zelda Cheatle, borrows its name from James Joyce's *Ulysses*. The line, he explains, is about how a person moves through a life meeting all kinds of people and, in the end, meets only themselves. "I think it sort of speaks to the humanism that I try to achieve with my photography," he says.

Books, and kids on ponies

Murphy, 66, did not set out to be a photographer. In school in Dublin, he was, by his own account, unremarkable, except in writing essays and sports. So he thought he could be a journalist. It was only after he left Ireland for San Francisco in his early 20s that photography took hold. "There was a public darkroom down the street from where I was living, and I taught myself how to print," he says. "That's sort of what I've come back to doing, which is going out with my camera and photographing life around me."

Murphy is entirely self-taught, and says so plainly. "There were a lot of yard sales and great second-hand bookshops in San Francisco, and I would buy the ones I liked." The list was full of classics, and yet "eclectic": Henri Cartier-Bresson, Robert Capa, Josef Koudelka, Helen Levitt, Jacques Henri Lartigue.

His first real break came almost by accident, in Dublin a few years later, sitting in his father's car (he was a doctor) during a house call. "Two children, about 12 and 13 years of age, walked past on horseback, no saddles," he remembers. The boys told him they kept the horses in their back gardens, and rode them to a revived medieval horse market. Murphy photographed it. *The Independent* in London ran the pictures across a full black-and-white page and a Swedish newspaper's local correspondent saw it and hired him. "It was all thanks to those kids on ponies," he says.

In search of humour

Ever since, Murphy has travelled across continents looking for, and capturing, life. Whether he's shooting in conflict zones or domestic settings, his photographs seek humour and convey a sort of irrepressible kinetic energy: be it on the cliffs of the Forty Foot swimming place in Sandycove, Dublin, which was inaccessible to women till about 1974, when a group of women invaded it to find there was no legal cause to keep them out; or the streets of South Beach, Florida, where a woman faces off with a bull terrier, baring her teeth at it.

Kolkata is a newer, gentler obsession. His wife Smita (sister of politician-author Shashi Tharoor) grew up there, and the couple now spend two to three months a year in the city. "As soon as I arrived, I loved it," he says. But loving a place is not the same as photographing it freely. "It's a very hard place to photograph," he says. "I spend more time not taking pictures than taking them because I don't want to keep repeating what's been done so well before. I'm trying to find my way into Calcutta."

Life is in Many Days *is on at the Museo Camera till October 25.*